

MGTP 416: Ethics in Accounting and Business

WINTER 2026

PROFESSOR: Wade Lindenberger, CPA (Inactive), MAcc

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CLASS MEETINGS: Thursdays 11:00 a.m. to 1:50 p.m. in OTRSN 1E106

OFFICE HOURS: Thursdays 1:50 p.m. to 2:30 p.m. in OTRSN 1E106

TEACHING ASSISTANT:

Alina Markova

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OFFICE HOURS: TBD

DESCRIPTION

Being an accountant carries enormous responsibility. You have a duty to your clients, your colleagues and the public to act with integrity and honesty. This course will provide you with a strong basis for identifying, evaluating and responding to ethical issues you will encounter as an accounting and business professional. This includes review of various professional codes of conduct (AICPA, SEC, TSBPA and IMA).

OBJECTIVES

At the close of this course, you will be able to:

- Understand the key concepts underpinning ethical theory
- Describe important considerations in applying ethical reasoning to potential ethical dilemmas
- Describe and comply with professional codes of conduct, including the AICPA, SEC, TSBPA and IMA ethics rules
- Define your professional responsibilities in the context of professional ethics, including understanding the concepts of integrity, objectivity, independence and other core values of the accounting profession, and applying these concepts to potential ethical dilemmas
- Analyze, apply professional judgment to and make decisions about current and emerging ethical issues facing the accounting profession and clients
- Understand your role in corporate governance and ethical management

REQUIRED TEXTS AND RELATED MATERIALS

- AICPA Online Ethics Library, which includes the *AICPA Professional Standards: Code of Professional Conduct* (<https://pub.aicpa.org/codeofconduct/Ethics.aspx>)
- TSBPA Code of Professional Ethics (https://www.tx.cpa/docs/default-source/about-tscpa-documents/Governance/tscpa-bylaws-and-code-of-professional-ethics.pdf?sfvrsn=3525e0b1_2)
- SEC/PCAOB Ethics & Independence Rules (<https://pcaobus.org/oversight/standards/ethics-independence-rules>)
- IMA Statement of Ethical Professional Practice (<https://www.imanet.org/career-resources/ethics-center/statement#:~:text=IMA's%20overarching%20ethical%20principles%20include,organization%20to%20adhere%20to%20them.>)

SCHEDULE (class dates are in **BOLD**)

Legend:

I = Independent, individual work only. No collaboration or consultation allowed.

G = Colleagues may work together in groups and turn in one project or assignment for the entire group.

C = Collaboration with classmates is allowed. However, each colleague must submit their own assignment.

Date	Class Topic & Activities	Assignments and Assessments
Week 1 – 1/8	Topics: Introduction to Course and Ethical Theory • Introduction to the course • Introduction to ethical theory • Formation of our company, including name, mission and vision	I: Read syllabus I: Personal Ethics Definition due on 1/18 at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 2 – 1/15	Topic: Ethical Reasoning and Decision-Making • Why ethics are important • Personal ethics definition • Ethical GPS • Giving voice to values • Formation of Ripped from the Headlines teams	I: Read AICPA Code of Conduct (pages 1 through 12) (see Week 2 Module for link to PDF) I: Read TSBPA Rules of Professional Conduct Chapter 501 (see Week 2 Module for link to text) G (two people): Ripped from the Headlines due on 1/30 at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 2 – 1/18		I: Personal ethics definition due at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 3 – 1/22		

	Topics: Ethical Reasoning and Decision-Making (cont.) Integrity in the Accounting Profession • Speaker: Michelle Wasserman • Identify ethical issues • Practice ethical dilemmas • Consulting time to work on various projects (as time allows)	I: Read AICPA Code of Conduct (pages 39 through 71) (see Week 3 Module for link to PDF) I: Read SEC/PCAOB Ethics & Independence Rules (see Week 3 Module for link) I: Speaker Reflection (you will have time to complete in class after the speaker concludes their presentation)
Week 4 – 1/29	Topic: Integrity in the Accounting Profession (cont.) • Identify ethical issues • Practice ethical dilemmas • Consulting time to work on various projects (as time allows)	I: Read AICPA Code of Conduct (pages 72 through 88 and 175 through 182) (see Week 4 Module for link to PDF) I: Read SEC/PCAOB Interim Standards ET Section 101 – Independence (see Week 4 Module for link) I: Evaluating a Company's Ethical Performance due on 2/13 at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas G (five to six people): Ethics Pitch Contest due on 3/4 at 5:00 p.m. in Canvas
Week 4 – 1/30		G (two people): Ripped from the Headlines due at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 5 – 2/5	Topic: Objectivity and Independence in the Accounting Profession • Speaker: Jim Deiotte • Identify ethical issues • Practice ethical dilemmas • Introduce Ethics Simulation project and assign roles within groups • Consulting time to work on various projects (as time allows)	I: Read AICPA Code of Conduct (pages 183 through 203) (see Week 5 Module for link to PDF) I: Read SEC/PCAOB Interim Standards ET Section 102 – Integrity and Objectivity (see Week 5 Module for link) I: Speaker Reflection (you will have time to complete in class after the speaker concludes their presentation)
Week 6 – 2/12	Topics: Objectivity and Independence in the Accounting Profession (cont.)	I: Read AICPA Code of Conduct (pages 204 through 228) (see Week 6 Module for link to PDF)

	- Identify ethical issues - Practice ethical dilemmas - Consulting time to work on various projects (as time allows)	I: Read IMA Statement of Ethical Professional Practice (see Week 6 Module for link)
Week 6 – 2/13		I: Evaluating a Company's Ethical Performance due at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas I: Midterm (Canvas) available from 12:00 a.m. to 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 6 – 2/14		I: Midterm (Canvas) available from 12:00 a.m. to 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 7 – 2/19	Topics: Objectivity and Independence in the Accounting Profession (cont.) - Identify ethical issues - Practice ethical dilemmas - Consulting time to work on various projects (as time allows)	I: Read AICPA Code of Conduct (pages 230 through 258) (see Week 7 Module for link to PDF) I: Ethics Simulation Advance Preparation due on 2/26 at 11:59 p.m. I: Ethics, Purpose and Leadership Survey due on 3/12 at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 8 – 2/25		I: Ethics Simulation Advance Preparation due at 11:59 p.m.
Week 8 – 2/26	Topics: Ethics and Privacy Ethics Simulation - Speaker: Pegah Parsi, UCSD Privacy Officer - Ethics simulation	I: Read AICPA Code of Conduct (pages 259 through 278) I: Speaker Reflection (you will have time to complete in class after the speaker concludes their presentation) G (four to five people): Ethics Simulation (we will conduct this assignment in class) G (four to five people): Ethics Simulation Group Work due at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas I: Ethics Simulation Individual Work due on 3/2 at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 8 – 3/1		

		I: Ethics Simulation Individual Work due at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Week 9 – 3/4		G (five to six people): Ethics Pitch Contest due at 5:00 p.m. in Canvas
Week 9 – 3/5	Topic: Other Core Values in the Accounting Profession - Identify ethical issues - Practice ethical dilemmas - Consulting time to work on various projects (as time allows)	
Week 10 – 3/12	Topic: Ethics Pitch Contest - Conduct Ethics Pitch Contest - Practice ethical dilemmas - Final reflections	I: Final reflections (you will have time to complete in class) I: Ethics, Purpose and Leadership Survey due at 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Finals Week – 3/18		I: Final (Canvas) available from 12:00 a.m. to 11:59 p.m. in Canvas
Finals Week – 3/19		I: Final (Canvas) available from 12:00 a.m. to 11:59 p.m. in Canvas

CLASS PARTICIPATION

Participation is critical in this course. I expect you to participate regularly in class discussions during lecture and in group projects conducted in class. Participation may include answering questions I pose to the class, being active in group discussions, answering polls conducted during class and any other activities that take place during class.

ASSIGNMENTS AND ASSESSMENTS

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Assignments

I: Reading

I will post in Canvas all class PowerPoint presentations and supplemental articles (either PDFs or links to articles). The syllabus schedule lists all reading assignments related to the required materials, but you should also check the modules in Canvas for assigned articles you will need to read for discussion in each week's class. As part of your preparation, I will expect you to complete all assigned reading before the class in which I will discuss the related topic.

I: Personal Ethics Definition

Based on what you learn in the first week of class, you will write your own personal ethics definition that you can use for the rest of the quarter and in the future.

G (two people): Ripped from the Headlines

You and a colleague will identify a current news article involving an ethical dilemma in the world of business and analyze it, submitting it as a PowerPoint presentation.

I: Evaluating a Company's Ethical Performance

You will identify a company and evaluate its ethical performance, submitting it as a PowerPoint presentation.

I: Ethics, Purpose and Leadership

On an individual basis, you will explore the various aspects of ethics, purpose and leadership and describe your ideas and thoughts on Canvas.

I: Speaker Reflections

We will have three guest lectures during the quarter. After each of these events, you will complete an individual reflection about what you learned.

I/G (four or five people): Ethics Simulation

We will give you and your team specific information that you will use to conduct an ethics simulation of a business case based on actual events. This assignment will consist of advance preparation, group work and individual work. We will complete the actual simulation during class time.

G (five or six people): 7th Annual Ethics Pitch Contest

This is our capstone project for the course. You will form a team of five or six people. Your task is to pitch your proposal that will describe ethical issues in the accounting profession and prescribe ways for the profession to address those issues in the future. Please review the project instructions for further information.

I: Final Reflection

At the end of the quarter, you will complete an individual reflection about what you learned in this course.

Assessments

Exams

During the quarter, I will give you two exams, a midterm and a final. See the schedule above for specific days when you will take these exams, as well as the materials covered in each exam.

GRADING

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Description	Points
Assignments:	
I: Personal Ethics Definition	5
G (two people): Ripped from the Headlines	10
I: Evaluating a Company's Ethical Performance	10
I: Ethics and Leadership	10
I: Speaker Reflections (4 @ 2.5 points each)	10
G (four or five people): Ethics Simulation Group Work	7.5
I: Ethics Simulation Individual Work	7.5
G (five or six people): Ethics Pitch Contest	15
I: Final reflection	5
Subtotal - Assignments	80
Assessments:	
Exams	20
Subtotal - Assessments	20
Total	100
Individually Graded Written Assignments and Assessments	67.5%
Team Assignments	32.5%

COURSE POLICIES

NOTE: Please see below for the late policy with regard to each of the above:

Assignments: If your assignment is one day late, I will assess a 25% penalty for a late submission. If your assignment is more than two days' late, you will receive a "0". For example, if the project is due on January 18, I will assess a 25% penalty if you turn in your assignment on January 19 and a "0" if you turn in your assignment on or after January 20. I will not provide exceptions.

Assessments: Because we will give you a 48-hour window to complete exams, if you do not complete an assessment during the 48-hour window it is available on Canvas, I will give you a "0" for that assessment and I will not provide exceptions.

Final course grade distribution is as follows:

A	>= 94	C+	77-80
A-	90-94	C	74-77
B+	87-90	C-	70-74
B	84-87	D	60-70
B-	80-84	F	< 60

APPENDIX A: ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

General

Academic Integrity is expected of everyone at UCSD. This means that you must be honest, fair, responsible, respectful and trustworthy in all your actions. I will not tolerate lying, cheating or any other forms of dishonesty because such actions undermine learning and the University's ability to certify your knowledge and abilities. Thus, I will report to the Academic Integrity Office any attempt to get, or help another get, a grade by cheating, lying or dishonesty, which will result in sanctions, up to and including an F in this class and suspension or dismissal from the University. So, please think carefully before you act and ask yourself the following questions:

1. Is my action honest, fair, respectful, responsible and trustworthy?
2. Is my action authorized by the instructor?

If you are unsure, don't ask a friend – ask me, an instructional assistant or the Academic Integrity Office.

(Source: Tricia Bertram Gallant, Ph.D., UCSD Academic Integrity Office, 2017)

You can view the complete UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship at:

<http://academicintegrity.ucsd.edu/process/policy.html>

You are expected to read the UCSD Policy on Integrity of Scholarship and act in accordance with the Policy.

For additional information about UCSD's Academic Integrity program, please go to this link:

<http://academicintegrity.ucsd.edu>

Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) for Coursework

The use of AI tools such as ChatGPT, Bing Chat, Bard, Claude, etc. is encouraged in this course. These tools have considerable potential to streamline and augment our work and you should use them for this class with the following caveats and conditions:

1. These tools should augment your work, not replace it. For instance, large language models can improve the quality of your writing, identify new sources, provide high-level summaries of complex ideas or terms, and pressure test your arguments for logical inconsistencies. These tools can help you come up with new ideas, overcome writer's block, or refine your original ideas. You should not use Generative AI tools to generate content that you simply put your name on. This constitutes an academic integrity violation, much like taking another individual's work and misrepresenting it as your own.
2. I will assume all students have access to and will use Generative AI and LLMs. If your work does not exceed the baseline quality level produced by AI, you should expect a low grade (C-, D).
3. If you use Generative AI for an assignment, be transparent about if/how it was used in a footnote or citation (e.g., link to the ChatGPT chat you created).
4. Large language models have documented issues with hallucination and inaccuracy (e.g., generating fake citations, failing logical arguments, misrepresenting sources, etc.). You are fully responsible for the content you submit in your assignments and will be graded accordingly.

Note: The above example policy is based on the text provided by Professors Thales Teixeira and Elizabeth Campbell available below.

APPENDIX B: PRIVACY PRACTICES IN THIS COURSE

This course is a community built on trust; as a learning community, we are collectively responsible for upholding privacy protections. In order to create a community built on trust and the most effective learning experience, our interactions, discussions, and course activities must remain private and free from external intrusion. We have obligations to each other to preserve privacy and cultivate fearless inquiry. We respect the individual dignity of all and will refrain from actions that diminish others' ability to learn.

As your instructor, I am committed to protecting your privacy by only using university-approved course technologies and adhering to the [Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act \(FERPA\)](#) and Campus Privacy Office guidelines. This includes using your educational data only as allowed by FERPA, for example, for legitimate educational purposes such as submitting your final grades to the registrar's office. Communications in this course are subject to the UC Principles of Community and the Electronic Communications Policy.

APPENDIX C: COPYRIGHT OF COURSE MATERIALS

Please carefully read the following information about copyright of course materials:

3. My lectures and course materials, including PowerPoint presentations, tests, outlines, and similar materials, are protected by U.S. copyright law and by university policy. I am the exclusive owner of the copyright in those materials I create. You may take notes and make copies of course materials for your own use. You may also share those materials with another student who is enrolled in or auditing this course.
4. You may not reproduce, distribute or display (post/upload) lecture notes or recordings or course materials in any other way — whether or not a fee is charged — without my express prior written consent. You also may not allow others to do so.
5. If you do so, you may be subject to student conduct proceedings under the UC San Diego Student Code of Conduct.
6. Similarly, you own the copyright in your original papers and exam essays. If I am interested in posting your answers or papers on the course web site, I will ask for your written permission.

APPENDIX D: STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES

If you have a disability or special need and require accommodation to have equal access to the classroom, you must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to me.

You must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to me to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. **No accommodation can be implemented retroactively.**

Please visit <http://osd.ucsd.edu/about/index.html> for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities at (858) 534-4382 or osd@ucsd.edu.

APPENDIX E: TITLE IX TEXT- OFFICE FOR THE PREVENTION OF HARASSMENT & DISCRIMINATION

The Office for the Prevention of Harassment & Discrimination (OPHD) provides assistance to students, faculty, and staff regarding reports of bias, harassment, and discrimination. OPHD is the UC San Diego Title IX office. Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 is the federal law that prohibits sex discrimination in educational institutions that are recipients of federal funds. You have the right to an educational environment that is free from harassment and discrimination.

You have options for reporting incidents of sexual violence and sexual harassment. Sexual violence includes sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, and stalking. Information about reporting options may be obtained at OPHD at (858) 534-8298, ophd@ucsd.edu or <http://ophd.ucsd.edu>. You may receive confidential assistance at CARE at the Sexual Assault Resource Center at (858) 534-5793, sarc@ucsd.edu or <http://care.ucsd.edu> or Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) at (858) 534-3755 or <http://caps.ucsd.edu>.

You may feel more comfortable discussing their particular concern with a trusted employee. This may be a Rady student affairs staff member, a department Chair, a faculty member or other University official. These individuals have an obligation to report incidents of sexual violence and sexual harassment to OPHD. This does not necessarily mean that a formal complaint will be filed.

If you find yourself in an uncomfortable situation, ask for help. The Rady School of Management is committed to upholding University policies regarding nondiscrimination, sexual violence and sexual harassment.